

ASSAULT RIFLES

After World War II, there was a demand for infantrymen to be equipped with fully automatic rifles, but the full-powered rifle cartridge was too powerful for accurate automatic fire. The solution lay in the intermediate cartridge that had been pioneered in the German StG44, a development followed by the widespread reduction in calibre sizes that led to the NATO 5.56 × 45mm cartridge replacing the heavier 7.62 × 51mm equivalent. The resulting weapon – the assault rifle – was further adapted to incorporate other new ideas, among them the “bullpup” design in which the trigger group was fitted forward of the magazine, making the rifle more compact.

Muzzle brake

▲ FN FAL PROTOTYPE

Date 1950

Origin Belgium

Weight 4.2kg (9¼lb)

Barrel 60cm (23½in)

Calibre .280

The FAL was originally developed with the German 7.92 × 33mm intermediate cartridge, although it went on to become a major export success (the basis for the British SLR) when rechambered for the 7.62 × 51mm NATO round.

Rear sight

Fire selector

Rear sight

30-round detachable magazine

▲ AK47 TYPE 56S

Date 1957

Origin China

Weight 5.13kg (11¼lb)

Barrel 41.4cm (16¼in)

Calibre 7.62 × 39mm

The most famous assault rifle in the world, the AK47 has undergone a number of changes over the years and has been widely copied. This Type 56S civilian variant was made in China.

Shrouded rear sight

30-round detachable box magazine

▲ STONER 63

Date 1963

Origin US

Weight 3.52kg (7¾lb)

Barrel 50.8cm (20in)

Calibre 5.56 × 45mm

Designed as a modular firearm, the Stoner 63 can be assembled to produce different variants that include a carbine, assault rifle (shown here), and several machine-gun configurations.

► GALIL

Date 1972

Origin Israel

Weight 3.95kg (8¾lb)

Barrel 46cm (18in)

Calibre 5.56 × 45mm

The Galil is based on the Finnish Valmet M62, itself derived from the AK47. The Galil comes in a number of variants that include a standard assault rifle, light machine-gun, and sharpshooter rifle.

Tubular butt stock folds to the right

Cocking handle

35-round detachable magazine

In-line plastic butt stock

Sling swivel

▲ M16A1 ASSAULT RIFLE

Date 1967

Origin US

Weight 3.64kg (8lb)

Barrel 50.8cm (20in)

Calibre 5.56 × 45mm

Introduced in the Vietnam War, the M16 series has developed into one of the world's key small arms. This example is fitted with an M203 grenade launcher.

Stamped steel body

30-round detachable box magazine

Butt stock